COMPANY DEEP-DIVE

Senior Vice President at Deutsche Telekom Believes AI Vendor Consolidation Will Enhance Customer Support and Workflow Automation

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SMART SUMMARY

Summary

The interview covers the evaluation and deployment of AI vendors for customer support and internal workflow automation at a large telecommunications enterprise, detailing the selection criteria, vendor performance, and future consolidation plans.

EXPERT BACKGROUND

- Senior Vice President overseeing marketing, procurement, training, ESG, and compliance at a major global telecommunications operator, with direct responsibility for evaluating and deploying AI-driven customer support and workflow automation solutions across a large, multi-country enterprise.

EXPERT SENTIMENT

- Believes the AI customer support and workflow automation market is rapidly evolving and expects significant consolidation and commoditization in the near future.
- Prefers to work with specialist vendors for enterprise AI solutions due to their focus on orchestration and compliance, but aims to eventually standardize on one or two providers for efficiency.
- Emphasizes **the importance of customer experience (NPS, CSAT) over pure cost savings, and is cautious about data privacy and regulatory compliance**, especially with US-based foundation model providers.

TAKEAWAYS

- The company currently operates a multi-vendor setup for AI-driven customer support and workflow automation, including ***Sierra***, ***Decagon***, ElevenLabs, Wonderful AI, and previously HappyRobot.
- Vendors are evaluated on a comprehensive set of criteria including business fit, performance, integration complexity, security, commercial model, vendor maturity, global capabilities, and innovation.
- **Sierra and ElevenLabs are currently the top performers, with Sierra excelling in complex customer experience orchestration and ElevenLabs leading in voice quality and creative content generation**.
- ***Decagon*** **is seen as a strong automation provider for simple workflows but lags behind** ***Sierra*** **in complex use cases**; Wonderful AI is still being evaluated and has not demonstrated clear differentiation.
- The company plans to reduce the number of vendors to one or two within 18 months, favoring those who can deliver both high-quality customer experience and robust enterprise integration, while maintaining compliance with EU data regulations.

AlphaSense Assistant is AI Generated

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Expert Bio

Senior Vice President of Marketing Communications and Devices at Deutsche Telekom Senior Vice President of Marketing Communications and Devices at Deutsche Telekom. Current customer of Sierra and Eleven. SVP at Deutsche Telekom who led vendor evaluation/procurement of Sierra and ElevenLabs against Parloa, PolyAI, Retell AI, Cartesia and others, and now oversees both day-to-day management and vendor governance/ROI. Senior Vice President of Marketing Communications and Devices at Deutsche Telekom. Reporting to the Board Member for Consumer Excellence, the expert is responsible for global brand management, integrated marketing communications, and the strategic procurement and marketing of mobile devices. This role includes full budget authority and oversight of international marketing campaigns across the European footprint. Prior to Deutsche Telekom, the expert was the Director of Brand and

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Marketing Communications at Telefónica Germany, leaving in July 2024. Reporting to the Chief Marketing Officer, the expert was responsible for the strategic repositioning of the O2 brand, end-to-end performance marketing, and managing a significant media and production budget to drive market share in the German telecommunications sector. The expert can speak to global brand strategy, device lifecycle management, digital transformation in marketing, and agency steering. They have implemented large-scale omnichannel marketing frameworks and managed high-level partnerships with major hardware manufacturers.

Interview Transcript

Client 00:00:00

Hi thanks for taking the time to talk with me today. I am interested in learning more about the tools large enterprise businesses are adopting for customer support, as well as general automation of workflows internally using AI. Based on your profile, it sounds like you've evaluated most vendors, and so I wanted to chat with you about your experience, who you're working with, and just get your general take on the market. It would be good, just 30 seconds on your background. I know we get it from Tegus, but always helpful to hear directly from you.

Expert 00:00:31

Of course. I'm currently working for, Deutsche Telekom, one of the world's leading telco operators. There I'm the senior vice president for marketing, procurement, training, ESG, and compliance. A very nice mixed basket of heterogeneous tasks that I'm confronted with on a day-to-day basis. Therefore, I'm more than happy to share all my knowledge and experience with regard to the latest AI, excuse my French, shit, in the voice AI space in particular.

Client 00:01:05

Got it. It would be good to understand before jumping more deeply in. It sounds like you've met with, heard from a bunch of different vendors. Who do you actually work with today?

Expert 00:01:17

Right now, we have a multi-vendor setup, being orchestrated to more or less have an ABCD test over the next two years, with a contractual obligation. Since, from my perspective, just a few words up front, it was too early to judge which player to go with on the long-term, because the entire space is evolving so incredibly fast that **it would have been foolish to directly** jump into things with just one player.

We initially came up with a long list of plenty of players, which we subsequently narrowed down to our current setup, which is ElevenLabs, ***Sierra***, ***Decagon***, first and foremost, and then we have one or two players additionally. There is Wonderful AI, which is a bit of a new kid to the block, as we are just about to kick out HappyRobot right now.

Client 00:02:05

Got it. You were evaluating HappyRobot, but you are about to stop working with them.

Expert 00:02:11

No, we even deployed them, because this was a recommendation of my CMO colleague from DHL, which is also based in Bonn, so it's just our neighbor. Since HappyRobot, primarily in its DNA, stems from rather logistics, he was pretty much convinced, and I got the recommendation. **I suffered from a bit of fear** of missing out there on this opportunity.

Therefore, I got started with a test pilot, but quite frankly speaking, **it still is pretty much disappointing**. Since, as I already mentioned, **they might be strong in the logistics context**, which partly is relevant to us as well. Of course, we have our delivery with regard to devices and stuff, but they are too niche and too specific to really create value comparable to the other players I just mentioned. This has been a short intermezzo, so to say.

Client 00:03:04

It would be good to understand that you started with a broader list.

Expert 00:03:08

Yeah.

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Client 00:03:09

How did you end up even with this group of five companies? What was the criteria you used? How were you breaking it down to get to this point?

Expert 00:03:19

We have a pretty comprehensive KPI and evaluation criteria set. It's actually eight clusters. Cluster one is business fit and use case alignment. Of course, very basic and very crucial, does it solve the business problem we are facing in the respective use case? If you talk about customer service, does it get the job done with regard to CSAT, NPS, and of course, solves the customer inquiry or issue? Moreover, can it actually scale and reliably scale across multiple business units? That is the first one.

Of course, closely attached to the first one is the second one with regard to performance and quality. Accuracy, latency, interruption handling, reliability, voice quality, very important, and reasoning capability when it comes to agents and their respective workflow capabilities. Clearly, very important is the enterprise integration. Since we at Deutsche have been operating in this field for more than 30 years, **our legacy systems are, with all due respect, a mess**.

It's super challenging to attach a new vendor. Attaching a vendor is one thing, but actually to unleash the full potential of an agent, you need to connect all the systems, connect all the dots with regard to the CRM system, the ticketing system, the billing system, all the APIs, the CCaaS, the identity management with regard to SSO and Entra ID, the existing cloud architecture. It's super demanding.

From a rather EU and particularly Germany-focused perspective, security and governance is super important. GDPR compliance, data residence is a thing. ISO, SOC two, auditability, super important. Of course, the respective commercial model. With regard to total cost of ownership and pricing transparency, scalability of pricing is super important since, of course, I have to justify these investments when I talk to my CFO.

Also not to neglect the vendor lock-in risk that comes with some of the players. Of course, vendor maturity. There are some new kids to the block, some elderly, so to say, with regard to financial stability and enterprise references, their product roadmap and trajectory, and also their willingness to really support us as a customer. Not only with regard to integration, but really with regard to listening to our feedback and potentially adapting their roadmaps according to our wants and needs.

Also, with regard to their global service and capabilities, because we're not talking about Germany and T-Mobile U.S. only. We're talking about this north to south axis from Poland down to Greece in the eastern part of Europe, where we have plenty of operating businesses in the respective countries. Of course, we want to make sure that our sisters and brothers are served equally. Very important.

A little addendum with regard to the integration and setup. Of course, implementation complexity with regard to time to deployment and the required engineering effort is super important. Last but not least, clearly innovation. Of course, we want a sustainable solution, not only for the time being but for the future. The speed of product development and the AI roadmap and trajectory and the frequency of model improvements and the new feature releases and so on and so forth.

This all together from all these criteria stems a balanced scorecard with a certain weight. We weighted them and, therefore, we constantly and continuously evaluate all players and keep on monitoring them. We have them in close watch to really make sure eventually we're going to end up with the right players. I love the analogy of it feels a bit like we're dating several girls, but we're not willing to put a ring on one of their fingers yet. We really want to stress test them to make sure eventually we're going to end up betting on the right horse.

Client 00:07:34

Got it. Do you think over time you will standardize on a single vendor, or will you always maintain this multi-vendor architecture?

Expert 00:07:42

No, this is clearly our ambition to reduce it to one, max two players, because handling several players is super exhausting. It's resource intense. **It's of course inefficient**, but it's worth the invest for the time being. After two years from today, this is the case, and quite frankly speaking, it's anyway my assumption of screening the entire market and industry. It's getting more and more commoditized, and my hypothesis is that aggregation is inevitable anyway, and perhaps some acquisition here and there. I'm striving for one player that has to be a one-stop shop and be equally great in every respective dimension that we've just discussed.

Client 00:08:25

Got it. I would love to go player by player, not necessarily through the criteria yet, but I want to understand how they presented themselves to you and what they pitched themselves as. I think that, like you said, it feels like everything is commoditizing or standardizing around a few sets of ideas and tools. When these vendors are talking to customers, they all present themselves quite differently. I would love to walk through ***Sierra***, ***Decagon***, ElevenLabs, Wonderful, even HappyRobot. When you did the initial evaluation, what was their sell to you to work with them?

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Expert 00:09:02
That's indeed the question I've been discussing with my team quite intensely as well, because of course, this is very important. Let's get started with Sierra, if this is fine with you.

Client 00:09:15
Yeah.

Expert 00:09:16
They positioned themselves, at least initially, because some of the players are a bit older than others. Wonderful is rather a new kid to the block, for instance. Sierra, back in the day, positioned itself as the AI-powered replacement or substitution solution for traditional customer service. Clearly as a premium enterprise platform for customer-facing AI agents. What they didn't do so much is emphasizing their underlying LLM. They pretty much focused on delivering human-like customer experiences with a very, very deep CRM integration, orchestration, and also enterprise governance. They put the customer at the center of everything they do and really want to make sure the NPS or the CSAT they achieve is better than the human agent ones.

Client 00:10:07
Quickly here before moving to ***Decagon***.

Expert 00:10:09
Of course.

Client 00:10:11
You mentioned, at least initially, ***Sierra***, even though the space itself is quite new, I'd say ***Sierra*** is the grandfather, the most well-known.

Expert 00:10:19
Absolutely.

Client 00:10:22
How has their pitch or positioning or product changed as they've worked with you over the past 12 to 24 months?

Expert 00:10:29
That's just what I'm deriving now, because, of course, they do not reposition themselves, obviously. From their roadmap and from our discussions that we clearly have with them, of course, the focus is more and more on the one hand side on agentic, because when we started, agentic wasn't such a thing yet. Secondly, more on the horizontal workflow orchestration. I would call them a juggler or an orchestrator or conductor, making sure that all systems together deliver the best possible solution to the customer that he's or she's most happy with. It's more and more on the horizontal or from the horizontal perspective. Less from a vertical perspective.

Client 00:11:18
Got it.

Expert 00:11:19
Of course. This is actually it.

Client 00:11:23
Instead of more customer support focus, it is becoming more horizontal agent deployments across Deutsche Telekom.

Expert 00:11:30
Absolutely. Not only focusing on telco as such, but different industries as well. As already mentioned, this is a very good proof point here. They are more and more becoming a bit of a generalist, let me put it that way. The almighty umbrella or bracket solution that brackets all together, something like that.

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Client 00:11:54
One thing I understood is that early on, Sierra was more like they would send their engineers and do deep integrations with you to build experiences. I've seen, more recently, that they've become more product oriented. They have tools that maybe your teams can use to build agents or workflows. Is that accurate, or is it still primarily deployed engineers helping you build some of these agents?

Expert 00:12:18
That's basically accurate. The thing, though, is that, quite frankly, from my Deutsche perspective, we would never be satisfied with a general solution. We are absolutely keen on having our bespoke and dedicated and tailor-made solutions to what we need, and therefore, it's inevitable to have their engineers and architects on stage or on our end, together with our engineers and our integrators from T-Systems and even third-party IT consultants, to really unleash their full potential. We wouldn't be satisfied with a standardized solution, to be honest.

Client 00:12:54
Makes sense. You were about to mention Decagon on the same set of questions here.

Expert 00:13:01
They pretty much positioned themselves as the, "We automate the contact center." This was a lot about automation. What they emphasized most was their measurable operational outcomes. They were keen on stressing their high automation rates and their reduced support costs, so they came from a business case perspective, their faster resolutions. Also, their enterprise-scale deployment. Its messaging was heavily centered on replacing repetitive support work with autonomous AI agents that is great potential.

This was actually true because having in mind that our call centers and the operational costs that come along with them, both internally and externally, are massive. They represent a massive cost factor on our P&L. They are first and foremost focusing on operational efficiency and automation, together with effectiveness, but it is more about efficiency and less about effectiveness.

Client 00:14:01
Got it. It's more about efficiency than anything else and driving those business outcomes.

Expert 00:14:06
Yeah.

Client 00:14:08
When you say automating the contact center, is ***Decagon*** remaining a vertical customer support focused platform, or have they also expanded like ***Sierra***?

Expert 00:14:17
They tried to expand like ***Sierra***, but to me, this is what I tell my team all the time, in my perception, ***Decagon*** **is the worse** ***Sierra***. They're rather like a fast follower of ***Sierra***, and I personally, if you were right now put a gun at my head and force me to choose one of them, I'd clearly go with ***Sierra***.

Client 00:14:37
Why is that?

Expert 00:14:38
If we look at all the criteria we've just discussed, all the KPIs, as I already mentioned, we're measuring both vendors qualitatively and quantitatively. We do our triangulation there. With the real call volumes they handle and in pretty much every single dimension, ***Sierra*** outpaces ***Decagon***, to be honest.

Client 00:15:00
What's the use cases? Maybe let's go through ElevenLabs and the others first. I want to come back to how each of these folks are performing. I think that's interesting. ElevenLabs, how have they pitched themselves and how are they positioned inside of Deutsche

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Telekom?

Expert 00:15:18

ElevenLabs originally clearly positioned itself as the voice layer. **It was a clear vertical with a strong focus** on voice, best-in-class voice quality, as they began as a text-to-speech provider, but now, of course, they have expanded into the conversational AI through its agents. **Its differentiation still remains, again, its top-notch voice quality**, its ultra-realistic speech. Also, its multilingual capability's super important to us in Europe, as already mentioned, its further **improved latency**, its natural and very authentic conversations. Compared with ***Sierra*** and ***Decagon***, ElevenLabs clearly starts from the voice infrastructure layer and builds upwards. A completely different angle.

Client 00:16:04

Got it. How do you internally interpret that, ***Sierra***, ***Decagon*** of their focus on building out platforms for customer experience and agents versus ElevenLabs starts voice first?

Expert 00:16:16

I would call ElevenLabs also, not perhaps the grandfather or the grandmother. It's also been there for quite some time. This is exactly the different angles they flew into the game. **They're still really strong on this**. For instance, what really differentiates them through this ultra-realistic speech capabilities is that we strongly use ElevenLabs for content assets and creative asset generation. Of course, when it comes to marketing, right now **ElevenLabs is still almost unbeatable.** They're really doing an amazing job there.

Client 00:16:52

Because the voices are realistic, people can pick up emotion, intonations and other things.

Expert 00:16:58

100%. The interesting thing is to share already, sorry for this little excursion, but I think it's quite interesting with regard to our evaluation, what we see there. Against all odds, and even though its agents is a bit rather new to the block, people rank ElevenLabs better since they really appreciate its naturalness, even though the solution might not be as good as Sierra's with regard to workflow.

This is really interesting. I would say that it's closer to passing the Turing test, **which gives it a great advantage** since people are super annoyed by the classic IVR, technocratic push or press button one, whatever. They're all fucked up by it. The more realistic, the better the result, independently of the actual solution that the respective vendor delivers, which **I found pretty much interesting and impressive and surprising**.

Client 00:17:54

Basically, even though their agent product is newer, when you ask folks to rate the experience with their agent, they rank it higher than Sierra and Folks.

Expert 00:18:03

Yeah. Even though the solution is inferior and worse.

Client 00:18:09

Wonderful, you mentioned new kid on the block. How have they fitted in?

Expert 00:18:15

They position themselves as the enterprise operating system for AI agents. I still try to understand their business model or their differentiator, quite frankly speaking. I've asked them several times, and it's very much about being above individual models or voice technologies, is a meta level they try to achieve. According to them, their value prop is enabling us as a company to, of course, build AI applications. Orchestrate multiple agents. Govern our AI deployments and integrate them with our enterprise systems. Routing across multiple foundation models is the value prop. They are less focusing on conversational quality and more on enterprise deployment and governance and workflow orchestration.

Client 00:19:06

That sounds not too different to what ***Sierra*** and ***Decagon*** are even trying to do for.

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Expert 00:19:11

Yeah. Thank you. That is my impression as well, but nevertheless, they somehow pitched it so well that I had to at least give it a test, but so far, I could not really recognize an actual difference or an actual game changer there. Perhaps I am still too stupid to get the point. This might be the case. Guilty as charged, but at least nobody could explain me comprehensively and substantially the difference. It's a bit like in Germany, we have the saying, it's old wine in new tubes, so it is a bit like potato, potato, if you will.

Client 00:19:52

Makes sense. You gave me some context on HappyRobot. Sounds like DHL somewhat referred them. You took a meeting and you piloted it initially?

Expert 00:20:03

Yeah, we did. Their positioning is, of course, that they are AI employees for logistics and supply chains. Unlike the others, HappyRobot focuses on this very limited industry-specific AI workers, rather than the general purpose conversational AI, let me put it that way. Their typical use cases are also completely different. Strong focus on freight brokerage and carrier communication and shipment tracking and whatsoever, you name it. They try to expand their model as well. Of course, they try to enter other verticals beyond logistics. I think they are fairly strong in their core competency, but **they massively struggle with regard to the expansion plans**, from my perspective.

Client 00:20:53

When you say massive, what gives you that sense? Is that from tests that you did with them or was it from your discussions?

Expert 00:21:02

No, from tests we conducted with them, and quite frankly speaking, also from my personal experience, because I recently had several incidents with them, when I tried to figure out where **my DHL package got lost**. I personally ended up screaming and yelling at HappyRobot that I want to talk to a human being, because it was hallucinating so horribly that it annoyed me. It was really, really painful.

Client 00:21:29

Got it. Personal experience with DHL. Internally, what was the test you conducted for it?

Expert 00:21:36

We wanted a test that was comparable to the others. I did not want a vertical logistics test, but also a customer service human agent replacement test. We attributed an equal amount of our call volumes to **HappyRobot**, as we did with all the other players. Of course, small amounts, pilot amounts so we're not on the risk of losing customer experience. We just compared the results and, of course, listened to some interactions and had qualitative interviews with our customers, quantitative larger samples. I cannot share the exact numbers for compliance reasons, but the result was crystal clear, let me put it that way.

Client 00:22:19

Makes sense. Going back to performance of these folks, ***Sierra***, ***Decagon***, ElevenLabs, Wonderful. It sounds like you have been giving each of them a proportion of your call volume.

Expert 00:22:31

Yes, sir.

Client 00:22:33

How have they each been doing, and how would you stack rank them today?

Expert 00:22:38

Let's perhaps get started with the stack rank.

Client 00:22:41

Sure.

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Expert 00:22:44

I'd say ElevenLabs and ***Sierra*** on one, ***Decagon*** on three, as the second place is by definition already occupied. HappyRobot on somewhere far beyond that, to be honest.

Client 00:22:58

Wonderful?

Expert 00:23:00

Wonderful. They have a pretty strong orchestration, both on three. Decagon and Wonderful on three, HappyRobot on five.

Client 00:23:10

Okay.

Expert 00:23:11

What **we observed, generally speaking, getting started with *Sierra* again, excellent customer experience, very strong orchestration,** and high quality enterprise deployments. Doing really well.

Decagon in comparison, strong automation rates, but not as strong. Operational efficiency, yes, particularly for customer support workflows with minor complexity. We are rather talking about eSIM activation or problems with your invoice or I want a new iPhone or whatever. The easy conversations. ElevenLabs**, again, very convincing market leading voice quality, excellent multilingual performance**, which is super important to us. Let me double down on it. Great low latency and I'd say a rapidly improving agent platform. They're trying to catch up.

Client 00:24:08

For Decagon, you emphasize good for these simple workflows with minor complexity.

Expert 00:24:13

Yeah.

Client 00:24:15

When you have complex voice use cases, where are those typically routed or who handles them the best?

Expert 00:24:21

Sierra.

Client 00:24:22

What do you attribute that to?

Expert 00:24:24

They all get the same amount. There is no difference here. We attribute minor, medium, and high complexity tasks to all of them to have a comparative chance to really look at them in similar comparable cases.

Client 00:24:38

Got it. If you had to think about why is ***Sierra*** performing better than ***Decagon***, they have access to same stakeholders and effectively the same information that ***Sierra*** and ElevenLabs do.

Expert 00:24:49

Yeah. Quite frankly, I'm not a technician. What I do know that their engineers and architects, of course, continuously and constantly improve their model and train the models together with our teams, and I'm not that deep into the topic, what they exactly do with it. To me, it's very much about the outcome, focus, and I want to make our customers happy.

I leave it to my team how they exactly get to this point. They all had the same starting point, so there's no competitive advantage. Back in

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the days, there was no competitive advantage. **Sierra is somehow really, with regard to solution orientation and their DNA and their models, overall outperforming the others,** and this is just a fact.

Client 00:25:37

When you say outperforming, you don't have to give me the numbers, but what are the metrics you're looking at on performance?

Expert 00:25:44

The core metric that really matters most to me is NPS and CSAT. This is what the entire story is all about. I want to make our customers happy, and I want to improve our current human agent NPS. This is important to me. I do not want to match it, but I want to really overtake the status quo.

We're not only doing this for the sake of a great ROI and efficiency and lower cost, which clearly is an important factor, because the business case, looking at the triple-digit number that we invest in our call centers, allows for big numbers with regard to the vendors **we're talking about, and would still have a positive return on investment**, which is great per se.

I would never, ever want to run the risk of again diluting our customer experience. This is the number-one focus. Of course, you can then evaluate NPS, generally speaking, customer satisfaction based on a subset of items, where you clearly see what contributes or distracts people from being satisfied.

Client 00:26:51

Got it. Obviously, you have this multi-agent or this multi-company setup right now. How is the decision made mainly? Is there a team of decision-makers? Is there one decision-maker at the end of the day? How is that made?

Expert 00:27:08

Yeah, it's me. It's actually me. I am the key decision-maker. Of course, I have my team, and they are constantly monitoring and tracking and preparing the presentation, everything. Of course, I am not the only one because I am responsible for training, and I am responsible for procurement, but not for customer service as such. Of course, I have one colleague who is responsible for customer service. Of course, we have our CEO, but he usually trusts us, so we together can make this decision.

Client 00:27:46

Got it. If you had to think about this multi-company workflow, do you imagine you will operate in this state for a couple of years, or are you going to slowly reduce the number of vendors you work with? How fast do you think you can go to the stable state of one to two from four to five, say?

Expert 00:28:03

We have a contractual obligation. We are in July, August already almost.

Client 00:28:11

Mm-hmm. Yep.

Expert 00:28:14

Another one and a half years, roughly speaking.

Client 00:28:17

Got it.

Expert 00:28:20

This is the point where I definitely want to narrow it down and break it down to max two players by then and kick out another two.

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Client 00:28:28

Got it. We talked a little bit about how each of them are doing. I know you mentioned you are not a technician or working hand-in-hand with them. I am curious how you feel, what each one could do better. From Sierra, what are the things you think they could do better as a vendor for you? ElevenLabs, Decagon, and maybe we can leave out Wonderful and HappyRobot because they are both newer and less integrated into the system.

Expert 00:28:55

With **regard to their weaknesses**, I would say Sierra is a premium solution, but it comes at a cost in terms of higher implementation complexity and also commercial cost. It's worth the effort because it's really best suited for very sophisticated customer experience use cases rather than the simple automation of Decagon. While **Decagon has its strong focus on customer support**, it's making it less flexible for broader enterprise AI workflows outside the contact center, which we look at, of course, as well.

ElevenLabs, as already discussed, historically in its DNA, is strongest in voice infrastructure rather than an end-to-end enterprise orchestration. Its enterprise governance and workflow capabilities are still maturing relative to the more established enterprise software vendors. ElevenLabs tries to catch up to become more of a horizontal player while Sierra tries to improve its voice quality.

Client 00:29:53

Within the contact center, what CCaaS systems have you standardized on, or do you have something custom-built in-house?

Expert 00:30:01

We have some custom-built in-house.

Client 00:30:04

Got it. For each of these vendors, they're integrated into your CCaaS?

Expert 00:30:10

Yes.

Client 00:30:12

If a call is not handled by AI, does it then get routed to your human teams?

Expert 00:30:17

Yes, exactly. Part of the workflow orchestration is also escalation. Instead of starting hallucinating, of course, the LLMs are trained to then escalate to a human agent and then support him or her as well. **This is a second sub-use case because the problem** is due to the fragmentation of our systems and legacy systems. It's quite interesting to share a little story there because whenever I visit our contact centers or our call centers and stand behind one of my colleagues, they have usually 10 to 12 browser windows open at the same time.

They're jumping and switching through them to be able to serve the customer adequately. They do it unbelievably fast. It's really like you almost cannot follow them. Therefore, an agent support also helps them doing their job more efficiently.

Client 00:31:11

Got it. You mentioned workflows outside the contact center. Can you give me an example of what you might mean by that? I understand, "Hey, I'm customer of Deutsche Telekom. I need to activate a phone number, or I need to make a change to my account." I imagine that's contact center use case. What would non-contact center use cases be in this context?

Expert 00:31:35

What we're currently setting up, which is my favorite use case, is a Magenta Concierge. We're embedding one of the agents into our network, so that if the both of us were Deutsche Telekom customers, for instance, and we are having this call right now, we could now, as customers, activate the concierge service. For instance, we could ask the concierge, "Okay, we need minutes of this conversation, of this telephone call. Please share minutes after the call."

The both of us would, during the call, decide to have lunch in New York City on Friday. We need a reservation at our favorite restaurant, Luigi's. The agent will place the reservation afterwards, share the invite for our calendars.

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Client 00:32:21
That is pretty cool.

Expert 00:32:23
So on and so forth. A bit of a Tony Stark-like, Iron Man-like J.A.R.V.I.S. support. Also, with regard to live adaptation translation. I'm German. **I have a horrible accent** when speaking English, so we could remove my accent, or I could speak German, and you got the live translation into English and vice versa. Plenty of opportunities there.

Client 00:32:49
Interesting. Are you testing all the folks for this type of use case, or is this not something that's live yet?

Expert 00:32:55
No, this is one of the use cases where we have a strong focus on ElevenLabs, to be honest. This is something where you need the voice quality, because if you have an **IVR sounding, technocratic, horrible voice**, it rather annoys people. It needs to be as authentic as a third party, a third person joining the call in a conference. It's your PA that joins the call and gets all the jobs to be done.

Client 00:33:23
That makes sense. Obviously, a lot of the use cases we've talked about have been customer facing. What about for internal workflow, like AI workflows? I imagine there's tons of them within an organization.

Expert 00:33:37
Absolutely

Client 00:33:39
like Deutsche Telekom.

Expert 00:33:41
Yeah. What we recently started is replacing our HR's IT support hotline and outsource it to an agent. This is a big use case, oftentimes neglected, but super important. If you have 200,000 employees as we do. You can imagine how much work and effort results from just people calling the IT hotline all day, every day.

Client 00:34:05
Yep.

Expert 00:34:06
This makes a big difference. Of course, as I already discussed earlier, we have our creative content generation use case as well. Not all of the players we've just been talking about is helpful there, but coming back to ElevenLabs, this is really doing an amazing job. We've got, I think it's called Creative Studio or so, where you can compose, or no, it's called ElevenLabs AI Music Generator, or Orchestra. I don't remember. You can compose your own music quite easily, come up with a multitude of variants there. Also, train the voice with our brand voices, which is amazing.

We can use their voices, pay them some royalties, and just record the respective dubbing over and over again, independently of any human brand speakers, **which has been quite annoying** because they usually sit in Portugal, then they are ill, or they are on vacation, or they are busy, or whatsoever. Now we can easily at our fingertips have them speak whatever they are supposed to speak in the perfect tonality and the perfect intonation without being tired, annoyed, exhausted, or what human beings usually are, which is also an amazing use case.

Client 00:35:23
Got it. On this HR IT hotline, who are you working with on that side? Is that Sierra?

Expert 00:35:30
That is Sierra, indeed.

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Client 00:35:33
Got it. Given it is a more horizontal product, it makes sense.

Expert 00:35:39
Exactly. Yeah, 100%.

Client 00:35:43
That's clear. One thing I've also noticed in the recent, call it six months, the foundation model companies themselves, like OpenAI and Anthropic, have been more aggressively building orchestration products or starting whole companies around AI transformation. Have you had discussions with them around any of these workflows or use cases?

Expert 00:36:04
Yeah, absolutely. We talk to them. What I perceive there is that their primary differentiation is the intelligence of the model itself. The reasoning, the coding, the capabilities, and the tool use itself, whereas the specialized vendors, like Sierra, rather differentiate through enterprise applications and orchestration workflow automation built on top of those models.

From my perspective, I'd say that anyway, the market's going to consolidate, and I expect one of these acquires some of the specialists. Right now, I personally prefer to really work with a specialist instead of the generalist for several reasons, as already mentioned. To me, it is even more of a black box where Anthropic and OpenAI store their data, what they do with it.

From a European legislation perspective, **this comes at a fairly high risk**. That being said, moreover, we are in close relationship with Perplexity, for instance, and rather with Google since, of course, we sell their phones, we use Android, we purchase their media space. OpenAI and Anthropic are rather no-goes to us.

Client 00:37:17
Got it. That makes sense and is clear. I think you are right. From an EU data regulatory perspective, unclear if data gets back used for training or for whatever, even if they say that's not the case.

Expert 00:37:31
Yeah. You never know.

Client 00:37:35
Also, the added benefit of ***Sierra***, ***Decagon***, ElevenLabs is for intelligence. They can use whoever they think is the best fit for the use case versus.

Expert 00:37:45
Exactly. 100%

Client 00:37:49
The model companies who are always incentivized to use their own model.

Expert 00:37:53
Absolutely. I couldn't agree more.

Client 00:37:57
Got it. Okay, this was a very useful discussion. I appreciate you doing all the hard work of meeting all these folks and sharing your insights with me.

Expert 00:38:09
My pleasure

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Client 00:38:11

We talk about five. I'm sure there are 30 you've chatted with over the past 12 to 24 months.

Expert 00:38:19

Indeed. I think it eventually will pay off. Otherwise, if you do not really engage with all of them, meet them, have your chemistry meetings, and give it a try, there's no chance to make a proper decision. It's hard work, but it's worth it.

Client 00:38:35

Perfect. Thank you. I appreciate you. Have a good rest of your day, and good luck.

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